

Μάγνης ὁ κωμικός

Old Comedy Fragments of Magnes the Athenian

eul_aid: cxa

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)
Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic \(com, frg\)](#)
Domain: [Κωμωδία](#) [Comedy](#)
Format: [Ἑμμετρος](#) [Verse](#)

Magnes was an Athenian comic poet active in the 5th century BCE, during the early period of Old Comedy. He is one of the earliest comic playwrights whose name has survived. Ancient records show he was victorious at the City Dionysia festival, though the number of his wins is uncertain; one later source claims eleven victories, while others suggest a lower number. He was a contemporary of other early comic poets like Cratinus.

None of Magnes' plays survive complete. He is known only through fragments and a handful of play titles mentioned by later ancient authors. These titles include *The Birds*, *The Frogs*, and *The Lydians*. It is important to note these are distinct from the later, famous plays of the same names by Aristophanes. The total number of plays he wrote is also disputed, with estimates ranging from two to nine.

According to modern scholars, Magnes' primary significance is historical. His career helps illustrate the formative stages of Athenian comedy before it reached its more familiar structure. The philosopher Aristotle mentions him as an important figure in comedy's early development. While the content of his work is largely lost, the titles suggest he used animal choruses, a theme that would become a staple in later Old Comedy. He represents the pre-Aristophanic landscape of the genre.

Works (2)

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